MUSIC MARKETING PLAN: THE WEEKND

By Lidia Daneshvar

ARTIST & BACKGROU

- Born Abel Makkonen Tesfaye in Scarborough, Toronto.
- Raised by Ethiopian immigrant parents.
- Known for mixing dark R&B, pop, mystery, romance, fame, and melancholy.
- His experiences heavily shape his music, but he emphasizes them to create a dramatic effect.
- Started uploading music anonymously in 2010.
- Did not show his face at first.
- This mystery piqued people's curiosity and helped build his underground fanbase.
- His brand began as dark and secretive.

AWARDS & IMPACT

Four Grammy Awards, along with Billboard Music Awards and American Music Awards

Headlined the 2021 Super Bowl Halftime Show

Expanded beyond music into acting through The Idol (2023) with Lily-Rose Depp and film projects like Hurry Up Tomorrow (2025) with Jenna Ortega

Known for philanthropy, including major humanitarian donations to Palestine

His awards, activism, and cultural influence make him marketable beyond music

ALBUMS & AMOUNT SOLD

EAS = EQUIVALENT ALBUM SALES, INCLUDING STREAMING + SALES

5.1M EAS

1M EAS

815K EAS

1.2M EAS

18.7M EAS

26.8M EAS

6.8M EAS

21.9M EAS

7.4M EAS

5.4M EAS

THE COME UP

Anonymous YouTube uploads in 2010

Early songs: “What You Need,” “Loft Music,” “The Morning”

Built mystery before showing his face

This became his first real marketing strategy

AbelOfficial

@abelofficial4553 2.06K subscribers 1 video

More about this channel >

HOME VIDEOS PLAYLISTS COMMUNITY CHANNELS

Uploads

Do It - Abel

31K views • 13 years ago

MIXTAPE ERA — XO

House of Balloons, Thursday, and Echoes of Silence (all 2011)

Later became Trilogy (2012)

Built the XO fanbase

Created a darker, more vulnerable R&B sound

Made fans feel like they discovered something underground

MIXTAPE ERA // XO

FROM KISS LAND TO MAINSTREAM BREAKTHROUGH

Kiss Land (2013) introduced his darker cinematic world-building

Beauty Behind the Madness (2015) made him mainstream

Hits: “The Hills,” “Can’t Feel My Face,” “Earned It”

He became commercial without losing his dark edge

GLOBAL SUPERSTAR ERA

Starboy (2016) marked a cleaner pop/electronic era

Collaborations with Daft Punk expanded his global audience

My Dear Melancholy, (2018) brought back darker emotional R&B

Fans connected the heartbreak themes to his public relationship with Selena Gomez

This era showed he could balance mainstream pop and personal storytelling

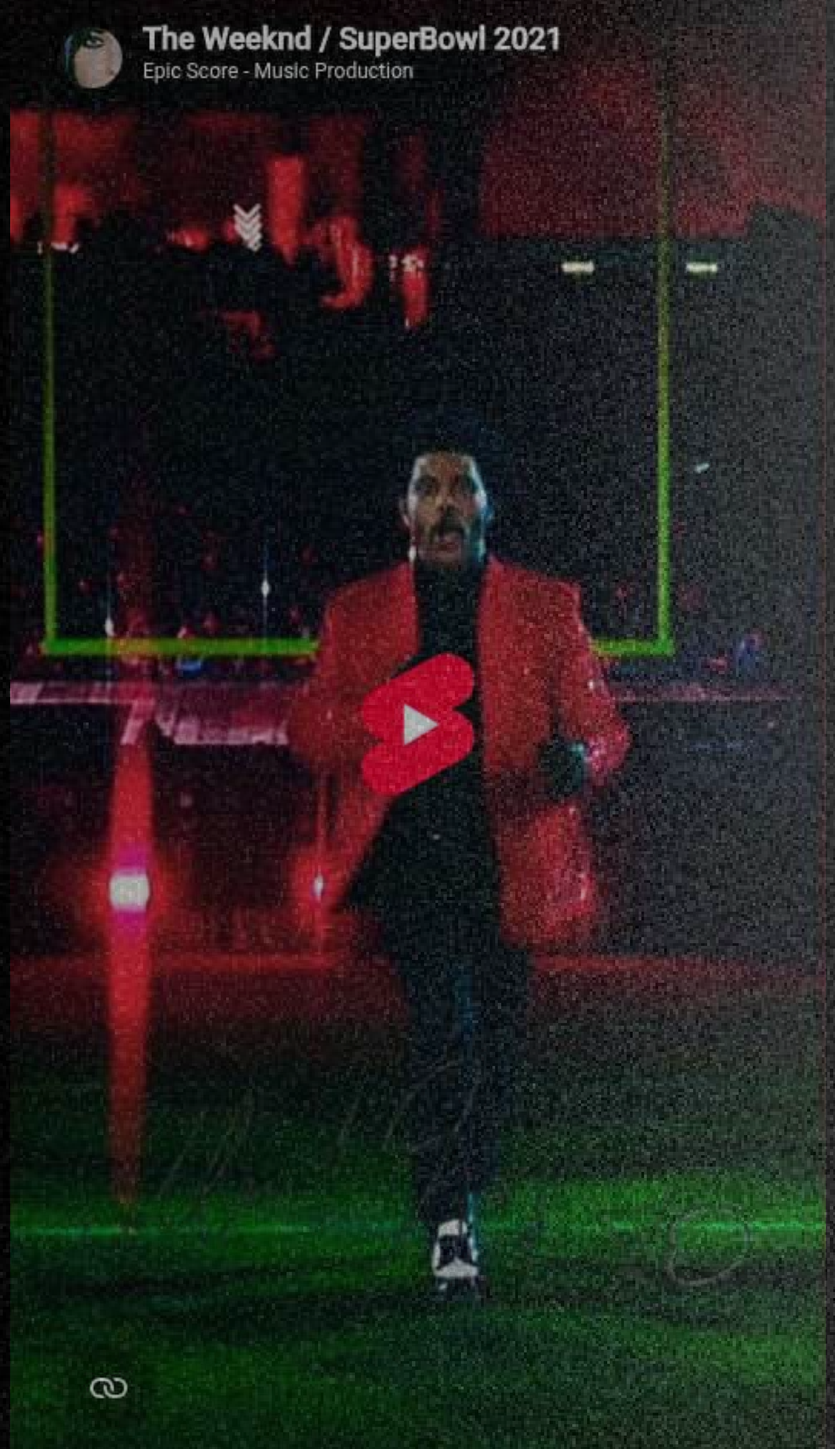
After Hours & Dawn FM

After Hours (2020) created a full visual world with the red suit, Vegas lights, and cinematic storyline

“Blinding Lights” became one of his biggest global hits

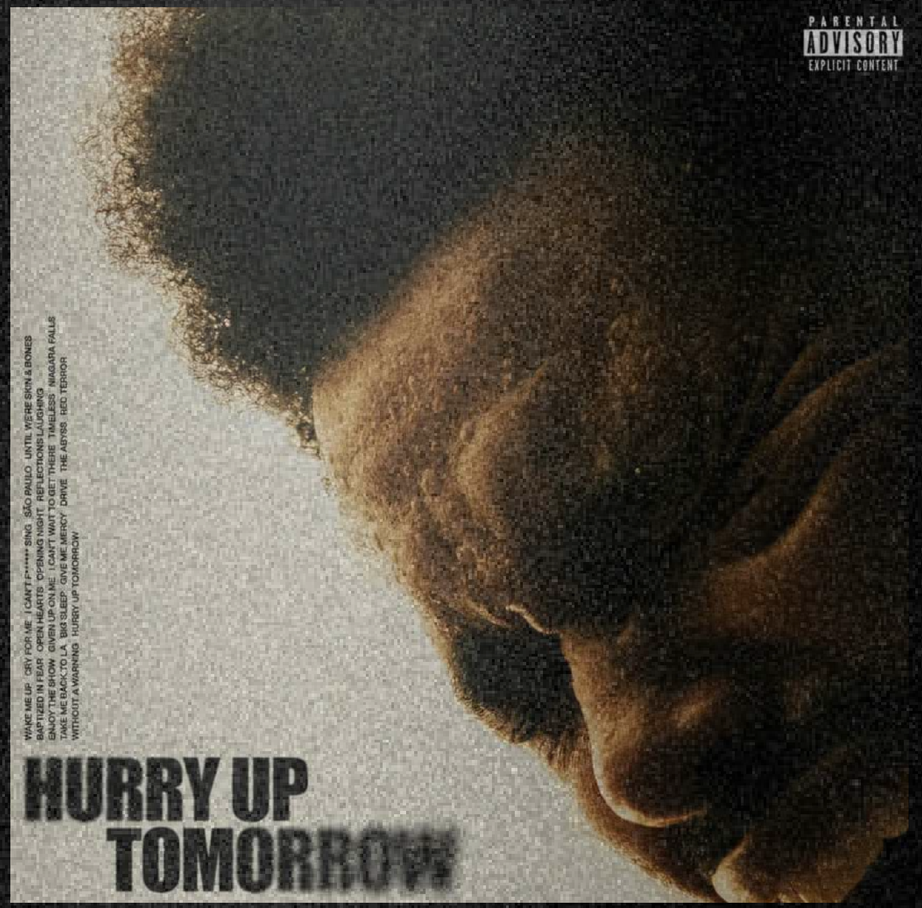
2021 Super Bowl Halftime Show brought the era to a worldwide stage

Dawn FM (2022) continued the concept-album style through a radio station / afterlife theme


The Weeknd / SuperBowl 2021
Epic Score - Music Production

CURRENT REBRAND

- Hurry Up Tomorrow (2025) represents the closing of a trilogy/era
- Abel has discussed moving away from “The Weeknd” name
- This creates a major rebrand opportunity
- The marketing plan should sell this as the end of The Weeknd and the beginning of Abel Tesfaye



MARKETING IDEA & TARGET AUDIENCE

Goal

Rebrand The Weeknd's current era as the final chapter of his persona and build excitement around Abel Tesfaye's next evolution.

Target Audience

XO fans / longtime listeners
Gen Z and young millennials
R&B, pop, and alternative fans
Fans who love cinematic visuals and storytelling
Casual fans from TikTok, streaming, and tour clips

ONLINE STRATEGY

- ***Campaign: “The Rise of Abel“***
- TikTok edits using official audio snippets
- Instagram countdown posts
- Spotify playlists for each era
- Website with hidden clues and visuals
- Augmented reality filter with red lights, sunglasses, and Vegas/night-city visuals

RADIO/STREAMING & TV IDEAS

Release a documentary-style video encompassing the transition called:

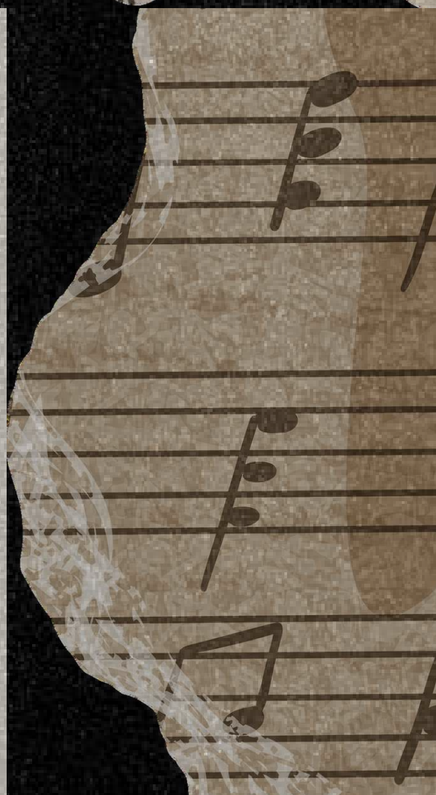
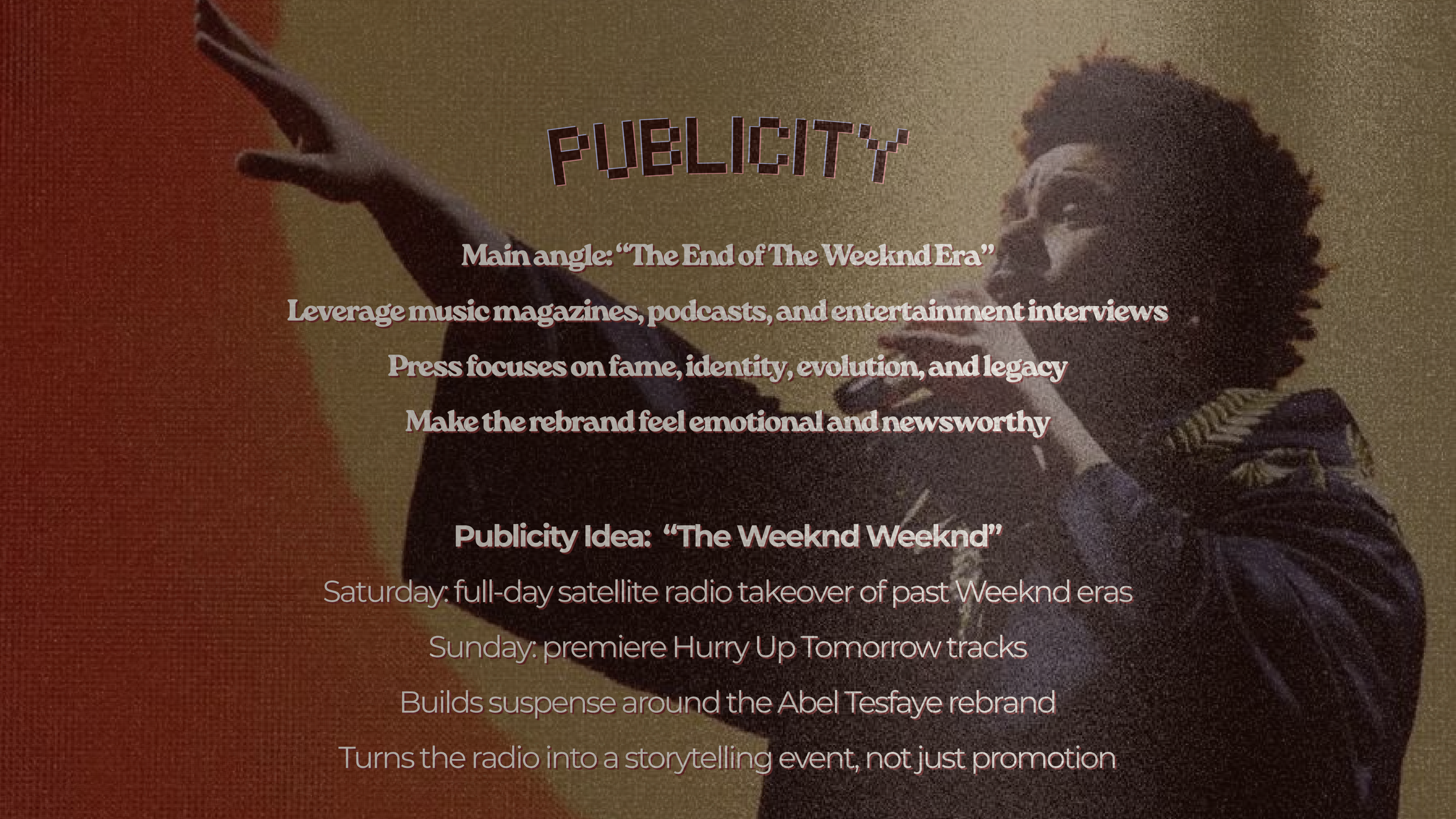
“Goodbye, The Weeknd”

Build hype around Abel Tesfaye’s next era

Push and lead single to pop, R&B, and satellite radio

te radio takeover: “The Weeknd Weekend”

rd shows and late-night performances

streaming platforms for outreach



PUBLICITY

Main angle: "The End of The Weeknd Era"

Leverage music magazines, podcasts, and entertainment interviews

Press focuses on fame, identity, evolution, and legacy

Make the rebrand feel emotional and newsworthy

Publicity Idea: "The Weeknd Weeknd"

Saturday: full-day satellite radio takeover of past Weeknd eras

Sunday: premiere Hurry Up Tomorrow tracks

Builds suspense around the Abel Tesfaye rebrand

Turns the radio into a storytelling event, not just promotion

PROMOTION IDEAS

Limited Vinyl Covers

QR-code city posters

Pop-up photo booth

"THE RISE OF ABEL" POP-UP EXPERIENCE

- *Traveling pop-up in major cities like Toronto, LA, NYC, and London*
- *Each room represents a different era: mixtapes, Starboy, After Hours, Dawn FM, and Hurry Up Tomorrow*
- *Fans scan QR codes to unlock hidden visuals, unreleased clips, and playlist links*
- *Ends with a final room called “Abel Tesfaye” to represent the rebrand*
- *Designed for TikTok, Instagram, fan photos, and press coverage*

THE RISE OF ABEL

POP-UP EXPERIENCE

An immersive, multi-sensory pop-up experience that takes fans through every era and ends with the beginning of Abel Tesfaye.

TRAVELING POP-UP
Major cities: Toronto, LA, NYC, London and more.

ERA ROOMS
Each room represents a different album era.
Mixtapes → Starboy → After Hours → Dawn FM → Hurry Up Tomorrow.

UNLOCK THE EXPERIENCE
Scan QR codes to unlock hidden visuals, unreleased clips, and exclusive playlist links.

THE FINAL ROOM
A reveal of the new chapter: "Abel Tesfaye".

Tour becomes the biggest marketing tool

Implement the pop-up experience at the tours to immerse fans

Live performances turn fans into promoters, creating buzz

Fans post concert clips, outfits, and visuals

City-specific merch creates urgency

The show should feel like the final chapter

NEXT STEPS AS ABEL...

Transition from The Weeknd persona into Abel Tesfaye as a more personal identity

Release future music under Abel's name

Move beyond era-based characters into storytelling rooted in his current life

Expand into film, acting, and visual projects

Keep XO fan loyalty while introducing Abel as the next chapter

By Lidia Daneshvar
THANK YOU!
#XOFOREVER

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